tions with the Congress. What has inflected that is a parallel development. On February 19, the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) switched camps and signed up with Team DMK. Though its influence has waned in recent years, the late actor Vijayakanth's DMDK had once essayed the role Vijay's TVK is auditioning for today: that of a formidable third force.

Premalatha Vijayakanth, party boss after her husband's 2023 demise, changed sides after the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) backtracked on a promised Rajya Sabha seat. The party had been a crucial part of the victorious AIADMK alliance in 2011. The DMDK, in fact, had won 29 seats—six more than the DMK.

Takeaways

- **Rebuffed on promised RS seat, DMDK switches over to DMK-led alliance**
- **Stalin forces Congress down from its demand for place in coalition regime**

But the late Jayalalithaa's AIADMK, with an imperious 150 seats in the 234-seat assembly, didn't need partners angling for spoils, so Vijayakanth ended up becoming Leader of the Opposition!

EACH SLIVER MATTERS

Its best days may be behind it, with the icon gone, but observers say the DMDK carries residual symbolic and organisational value, with pockets of support in northern and central Tamil Nadu and among sections of the urban lower middle class. This is a thinner but still significant remnant of the 8 per cent vote share it had in the 2006-11 phase. Potentially crucial slivers in a tight election, if strategically distributed.

CHASTENED CONGRESS

The alliance with the Congress is close to being sealed, though Stalin rejected its proposal for a coalition government. It had initially sought a "respectable" share of seats—up to 45—and a "role in governance" commensurate with its national stature. That's tapered down to more realistic levels, with cohesion being prioritised over individual grandeur. Talk is of the '25 + 1' formula being retained—over 10 per cent of seats and one ticket to the Rajya Sabha. A lower scale of ambition, but perhaps not unsuited to the Congress.

As for the AIADMK, after a solo sortie in the 2024 Lok Sabha election fetched it zero seats, it has curbed its bravado and sought refuge in formation flying. An iffy remarriage with the BJP last April set things off. It wanted to lasso in Vijay's fledgling outfit, but the latter's growing profile put paid to that. Yet, by January, its front absorbed T.T.V. Dhinakaran's splinter *kazhagam*, Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK), and the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK), a force in northern Tamil Nadu.

The last is another evolving story within this shifting calculus. Eclectic in its affiliations over the decades, the public spat between founder S. Ramadoss and his son and former Union health minister Anbumani Ramadoss has raised the prospect of its Vanniyar vote bank, once projected as a consolidated bloc, being fragmented.

Anbumani has chosen to join the AIADMK alliance, while Ramadoss Sr had reportedly shown interest in the DMK. But the latter needs to look out for the sensitivities of the Dalit-oriented Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), no friend of the PMK or its politics. ■

▶ WEST BENGAL

SIR Gets Judicial Monitors

The millions of pending disputes in Bengal voter deletions spark unusual nth-hour court intervention

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

FOUR DAYS BEFORE D-DAY, THE SUPREME COURT decided to raise its supervisory alert on West Bengal's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls to Code Orange levels. A rare direct judicial intervention in what would ordinarily have been a routine administrative exercise, the February 24 order laid bare some stark gaps in the original SIR mechanisms. Finding these had failed to inspire confidence or ensure timely resolution of millions of disputed claims, a three-judge bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant authorised an army of serving and retired judicial officers to be deployed to assist in the process.

UNDER THE SCANNER Election officials in Kolkata working on the SIR list, Dec. 27



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